



S. Europe

Diocletian's Palace

An extensive Roman palace and garrison complex built by the Emperor Diocletian for his retirement

Much of the central old town of present-day Split, on the Croatian coast, occupies the walled area of streets and buildings known today as Diocletian's Palace. The residence itself, however, is only a part of a fortified complex that Diocletian had built in anticipation of his retirement as Roman emperor in 305 CE.

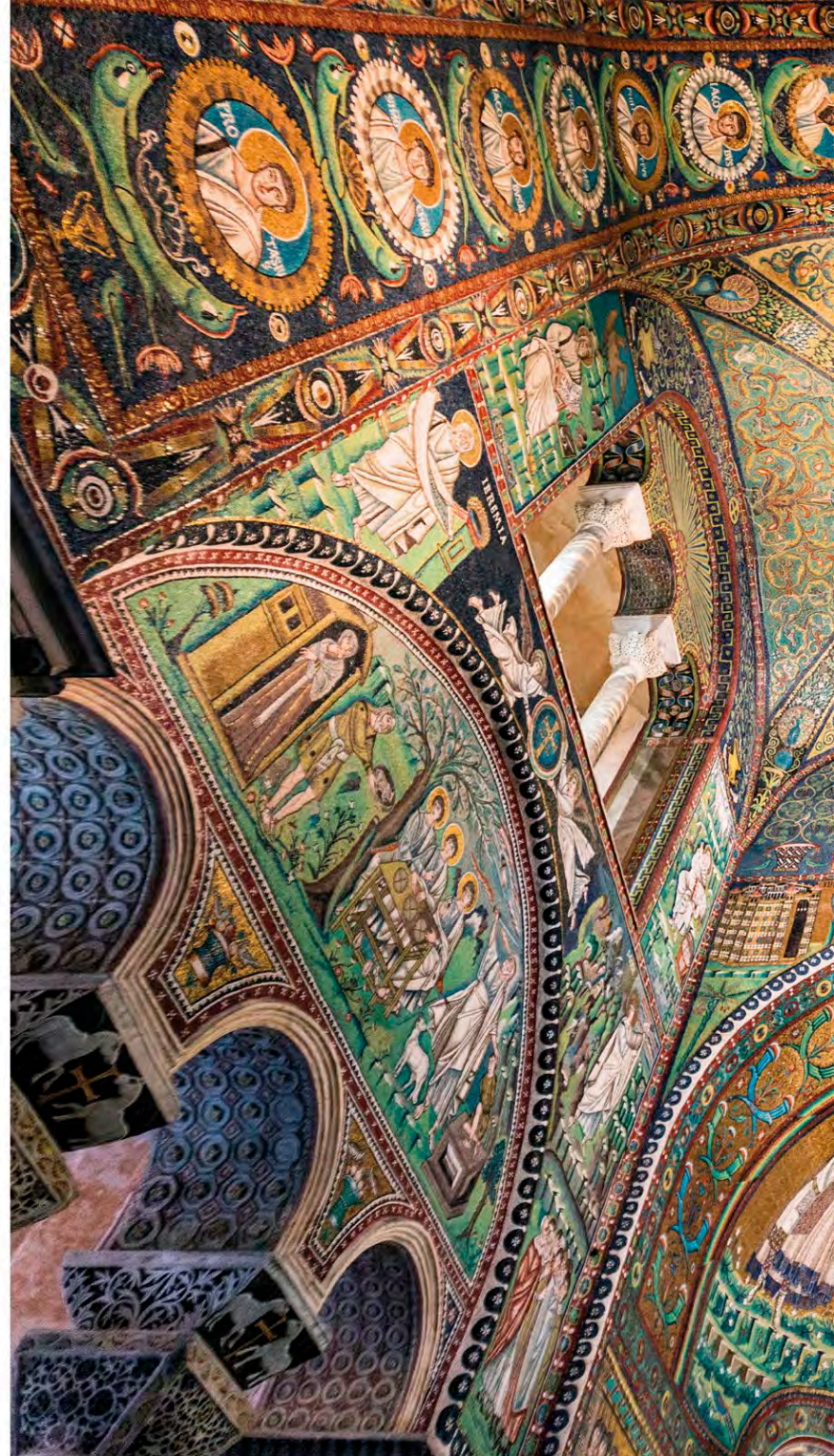
Structure of the citadel

Protected on three sides by high walls and watchtowers, and on the south side by the sea, the fortress is divided in two by a street between the western Iron Gate and the eastern Silver Gate. To the north is the garrison and a residential area, and in the north wall is the magnificent Golden Gate, which leads onto the main north-south street, down to the central square, the Peristylum. This forms the entrance to the southern half of the complex, containing public buildings and the emperor's luxurious residence overlooking the sea. After the Romans abandoned the fortress, the buildings and spaces in the walls were taken over as private dwellings and shops, and today they are an integral part of the city.



△ ADAPTED FORTRESS

The main body of the Cathedral of St. Domnius is formed from the Roman Imperial mausoleum, to which a bell tower was added in the 12th century.



THE PLAN OF THE BASILICA

The blend of Roman and Byzantine elements gives the basilica a complex structure: the overall octagonal floor plan contains an inner octagon of arches supporting the tiered tower, and the narthex (entrance lobby) is unusually set tangentially to the perimeter rather than aligned with the main axis of the church.

